

Gods at PLAY

Wendy Doniger slaughters a few sacred cows as she retells the story of the Hindus



**THE HINDUS:
AN ALTERNATIVE
HISTORY**
by WENDY DONIGER
Penguin/Viking
Price: Rs 999
Pages: 779

| By S. Prasannarajan |

The subtitle of Wendy Doniger's mammoth volume on the Hindus exudes a whiff of subversion. Before we turn the first page, we may very well ask: Is there an official history of the Hindus, or for that matter, Hinduism? The answer is an emphatic No. What we have is a labyrinthine narrative tradition: stories within stories within stories, an embarrassment of intertextual riches. There are no undisputed codifications; and no unbreakable edicts either. The Hindu faith is sustained by the plurality as well as the polyphony of the sacred, and it is not answerable to anyone who claims to have copyright over the scriptures. Hinduism—the “ism” itself a vestige of the West's discovery of the ways of the Hindus—is not a religion of the Book, but books have made it so exuberantly

fluid. So Doniger is not exactly offering us an alternative history. She is rereading the stories with the excitement of a mythomaniac, and we have no choice but to share her joy as she plays with the motifs and metaphors scattered across the narratives. And she is more than adequately qualified: with doctorates in Sanskrit and Indian studies, this professor of History of Religions at the University of Chicago is the foremost scholar of Hinduism in the West. In this one, her most ambitious work, Doniger portrays herself as the provocateur. There is no need for her to try so hard as the stories themselves are highly provocative.

They are stories that lie orphaned outside the sacred realm of Sanskrit, the professional language of the chroniclers of the Hindu lore. “Part of my agenda in writing an alternative history,” writes Doniger at the outset, “is to show

BANDEEP SINGH/www.indiatodayimages.com

